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PARTICIPATE IN GROUPS AND/OR TEAMS TO RECOMMEND SOLUTIONS TO PROBLEMS

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SECTION A: FORMATIVE ASSESSMENT

QUESTION 1

When making contributions to solve problems in a team, the following must be considered:

1. Understand the problem clearly - Make sure you know what the real problem is, not just the symptoms. Ask questions.

2. Organisation's goals and objectives - Your solution must align with what the organization wants to achieve.

3. Available resources- Consider time, budget, staff, and computer technology available.

4. Team members' skills and knowledge- Consider what each person can contribute.

5. Consequences and risks- Think about what will happen if your solution fails and risks involved.

6. Company policies and procedures - Solution must follow company rules and South African laws.

7. Time frame / Deadlines - Solution must be achievable within the given time.

8. Communication - Make sure your contribution is clear, respectful and understood by all team members.

9. Objectivity - Be unbiased, focus on facts not personal feelings.

10. Feasibility- Solution must be practical and implementable.

Example: At Boxer, if POS is slow, my contribution must consider budget for new internet, staff training needed, and not disrupting customers.

Question 2

Two ways of reaching a decision as a team:

1. Consensus Decision Making:

This is when all team members discuss until everyone agrees on one solution. Everyone's opinion is heard and final decision is supported by all.

Advantages:

- Everyone feels valued and part of decision.

- High commitment to implement decision.

- Better quality decision because all ideas considered.

- Reduces conflict later.

Example: At Boxer, the team discusses how to solve load shedding problem. All members (manager, IT, cashiers) discuss until they agree to buy UPS. Everyone will support it.

2 . Majority Voting:

Team members vote for preferred option and option with most votes wins.

Advantages:

- Fast and democratic.

- Fair, everyone's vote counts equally.

- Useful when time is limited.

- Easy to implement.

Example: Team must choose between two suppliers for new PCs - Supplier A and Supplier B. Team votes, Supplier A gets 4 votes vs 2 votes, so Supplier A is chosen.

Other method (optional): Leader Decides after consultation- Leader listens to team then makes final decision. Advantage: Fast when urgent decisions needed.

Question 3

To be perceived as valued and positive, a team member must have:

1. Reliability and Punctuality -Always on time, do what you promised, meet deadlines.

2. Good Communication Skills - Listen actively, speak clearly, share information.

3. Positive Attitude - Be optimistic, motivate others, don't complain.

4. Cooperation and Teamwork- Willing to help others, share knowledge, put team first.

5. Respect - Respect other members' opinions, culture and diversity.

6. Accountability - Take responsibility for your actions and mistakes, don't blame others.

7. Competence / Skills- Have knowledge needed for the task (e.g. computer skills) and willing to learn.

8. Problem Solving Ability- Bring solutions not problems, be creative.

9. Flexibility- Willing to adapt to change and do different tasks.

10. Honesty and Integrity - Be truthful, ethical and trustworthy.

If you have these, team members will see you as valuable and want to work with you.

Question 4

I. Four obstacles:

1. Poor Communication- Members don't share information, misunderstandings.

2. Lack of Resources* - No computers, slow internet, no budget, no backup power during load shedding.

3. Conflict between team members- Personality clashes, fighting over ideas.

4. Lack of clear goals / Poor leadership- Team doesn't know what to achieve, no direction.

5. Other examples:- Lack of training, Absenteeism, Time pressure, Resistance to change.

ii. How to overcome obstacles:

1. For Poor Communication: hold regular meetings, use WhatsApp group, email minutes, encourage open communication, listen actively.

2. For Lack of Resources: plan budget properly, request resources from management in advance, prioritize what is most important, improvise with what you have.

3. For Conflict: Address conflict immediately, use mediator (manager), focus on problem not person, respect each other, compromise.

4. for lack of Clear Goals / Poor Leadership:Set SMART goals (Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Realistic, Time-bound), appoint strong team leader, clarify roles and responsibilities, create action plan with deadlines.

Example at Boxer: To overcome slow internet obstacle, team agreed to upgrade to 100Mbps and use LTE backup.

Question 5

Technique 1: Brainstorming

This is a technique where team members gather and generate many ideas quickly without judging them. All ideas are written down, then best ideas are selected.

How it works:

- Define problem (e.g. tills freezing)

- Set time limit (e.g. 20 minutes)

- Everyone shouts ideas, no criticism

- Write all ideas on flipchart

- Evaluate ideas and choose best.

Advantages: Generates many ideas, encourages creativity, everyone participates.

Example: Boxer team brainstorms reasons why stock count is wrong - ideas: theft, scanning error, supplier short delivery, system error.

Technique 2: Root Cause Analysis (5 Whys / Fishbone Diagram)

This technique finds the real cause of problem, not just symptoms. You keep asking "Why?" 5 times until you reach root cause. Or use Fishbone (Ishikawa) diagram with categories like People, Machine, Method, Material.

How it works (5 Whys):

Problem: POS slow.

Why 1: Why slow? Internet slow.

Why 2: Why internet slow? Too many users on WiFi.

Why 3: Why too many users? No password on WiFi.

Why 4: Why no password? Manager didn't set it.

Root cause: No Wi-Fi security.

Advantages: Solves problem permanently, prevents recurrence.

Other techniques you can use: SWOT Analysis, Mind Mapping, Nominal Group Technique.

Question 6

If you present findings late, the adverse effects are:

1. Delays decision making - Management cannot make decisions on time, organization loses opportunities.

2. Loss of trust and credibility- Supervisor and team will see you as unreliable and not trust you with future tasks.

3. Affects team performance- Other team members waiting for your report cannot do their work, whole project delayed.

4. Financial loss - Organisation may lose money, e.g. if report about stock loss is late, more theft happens.

5. Disciplinary action- You may get written warning, poor performance review or even lose job.

6. Poor customer service - If problem is customer complaints and report is late, customers continue suffering.

7. Creates conflict - Team members become frustrated and angry with you.

Example: If I was delegated to report on slow POS system and I report 2 weeks late, management cannot buy UPS in time, shop continues closing during load shedding and loses R5,000 per day.